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Living Happily

The very idea that virtue might have any role in flourishing or happiness has seemed, for about two hundred years, deeply unlikely. Philosophers in that period have been among the most robust in insisting that the whole idea of thinking that virtue could lead to happiness is absurd. Bentham says of the idea that virtue is sufficient for happiness, 'What benefit, in any shape, could be derived from impregnating the memory with such nonsense? What instruction from a self-contradictory proposition?'[1] Nietzsche is even more dismissive. 'Such assertions and promises as those of the antique philosophers concerning the unity of virtue and happiness or the Christian, "But seek ye first the kingdom of God, and his righteousness, and all these things shall be added unto you" have never been made with total honesty and yet always without a bad conscience: one has advanced such propositions, which one very much desires to be true, boldly as to the truth in the face of appearance.'[2] This idea, that there is some kind of naive wish-fulfilment or over-optimism in the claim that the virtuous are happy, lingers more effectively than actual arguments. Up to this point I have used the interim term 'flourishing' rather than happiness, but this has not been intended to avoid the issue stated brutally by Bentham and Nietzsche, and I shall now talk in terms of happiness.

We should begin by reflecting that there is an oddity here. It is common to find this assumption, that there must *of course* be a conceptual gulf between virtue and happiness or flourishing, making it problematic or even absurd to think that happiness could require being virtuous. And yet

[1] Bentham (1983: 300). This is his response to Cicero's *Tusculan Disputations*, whose last book argues that virtue is sufficient for happiness. Bentham does not mention that he chose this book to study for his final examination at Oxford, boasting to his father about how well he performed (presumably not by venting the above response).

[2] Nietzsche (1997: 456).

few of us have any half-way definite account to give either of what virtue is or of what happiness is. Where does the assurance come from that virtue and happiness *must* come into conflict when there is so little agreement (general or among philosophers) about what either is? The assurance may partly come from other sources,[3] but it is likely to come at least in part from confusion about what virtue and happiness are. The revival of ethical thought which gives a role to virtue has helped us to get clearer about virtue, but the same can't be said for the recent surge of work on happiness in a number of academic areas as well as in popular culture. We have recovered the thought that happiness is an important concept for ethics, but there has never been a greater cacophony of voices from different directions on the topic of what happiness is.[4]

As with virtue, I think that we can be helped here by looking at the resources we can find in traditions of ethical enquiry preceding the era in which thinkers as different as Bentham and Nietzsche could be equally at a loss when thinking of virtuous flourishing lives. I shall therefore start by looking at flourishing or happiness as that figures in eudaimonist accounts. I shall claim that it is not only viable but natural for us to think of happiness in the way these theories develop it. (This account will not be complete until the next chapter, which brings it together with the present account of virtue.) I will then look at the major competing claims as to what happiness is which I can extract from a (necessarily very selective) survey of current views, asking about the extent to which these might suggest modifications to a eudaimonist account.

Eudaimonism

What is a eudaimonist account? An account of how to live, one in which happiness, *eudaimonia*, is central. While *eudaimonia* just means 'happiness' in the ancient world, it is obviously, for us, to be understood in terms of the role it plays in a eudaimonist account. Here, happiness is a central concept (not, and this is important, the basic or foundational concept), but

[3] e.g. identifying virtue with morality, and assuming uncritically that morality is about others' interests and happiness about your own, making it appear problematic that one should seek one's own interests in a way that gives a more than instrumental role to those of others.

[4] See Haybron (2008), Kraut (1979), Layard (2005), Myers (1992), Seligman (2002), Tiberius (2008). Accounts of virtue vary widely, as we've seen, but with happiness there is even less agreement.

it is not the first concept that we encounter. Rather, the entry point for ethical reflection[5] is thinking about how your life is going, thinking that can only arise in people who already are, or are becoming, adult, and who are aware that everything in their life is not satisfactory. Nearly all of us engage in this reflection, since it is exceptionally rare for our lives to be completely satisfactory and to give us no basis for reflection on how they are going. Some people do seem never to be led to step back from their lives and reflect on them; usually this is because their lives have been fortunate and they have never had to question the relative importance in their lives of fortune and of the way they live their lives.

So you step back from the ongoing happenings of your life, and wonder about how and in what direction it is going. This at once reveals a fundamental difference between two ways in which you can regard your life. One perspective is the everyday one, in which you do one thing after another, one action following another chronologically. You get up, go to work and so on, one thing after another until eventually it comes to an end when your life does. This is the linear way of thinking of your life, and it is important as you get through the day, and in many other ways. But reflection reveals another way in which your life enters your thoughts about it. We can call this the structured way of thinking of your life.

Take the action you are now doing or have just done. You can think of it in the linear way, as coming after the previous action and going on to (perhaps giving rise to) the next one. But you can also ask yourself about it, *why* am I doing this action (and not another one)? With very trivial actions there may be no substantive answer to this, but with most actions there is. Why are you doing exercises?—To keep fit. Why are you keeping fit?—To be healthy. Why are you aiming to be healthy? Or: why are you reading that book?—To learn how to make a software program. Why are you aiming to make a software program? – To become a computer expert. – Why are you aiming to become a computer expert?—To have a good career. Why are you aiming at having a good career? These ways of following through the question 'Why?' indicate what you are aiming at in what you do, not just now but in your life more broadly. Actions are related, then, not just chronologically but also by the relation of one being

[5] This is how I characterize the starting-point for ethical theory in the ancient world in Annas (1993); I have come (in large part through teaching) to think it still available, and compelling as a starting-point, in the contemporary world.

for the sake of another, and as you think of them in this way in your own life, it reveals what you are aiming at in doing what you are doing. One point that emerges rapidly is that the goals we have in life are *nested*: the answers to the question about reading the book become ever more general, each smaller goal turning out to be for the sake of a broader one. Your actions fit into structured patterns in your life; a snapshot of what you are doing at one time turns out to reveal, when we think about these structures, what your broader aims and goals in life are.

Thus from reflecting about things I do every day I come to find that I have several broader and long-term goals. I want to be healthy, to have a good career, to have a good family life, to take a safe and simple example. Do we end there? At first it may seem reasonable to do so. I have several long-term goals; what is wrong with that? A life with any degree of complexity will surely have several larger goals within which smaller everyday goals are nested. But in fact once the structured way of thinking about our actions gets going, it turns out to have a unifying tendency which has us thinking about the goals revealed in our lives. First, the goals I have need to be compatible, since I don't stay statically at the stage of wanting, for example, a good career and a good family life. In some circumstances I can aim at both without worrying about possible conflicts, but in many I will have to give some thought to conflicts in achieving these jointly. My partner may want to move just at the point that my career is taking off in a place favourable to it. This sort of consideration comes up all the time with our various goals, and so the thinking that makes clear to me what my goals are in the way I am acting and living my life is also thinking that raises the question of how these goals are to be made consistent. In everyday life we do this all the time without thinking much about it when the answers are obvious: we stop working for a degree once we decide that we no longer value the having of the degree, or need a different degree, for example. But when our goals are such that there is a built-in conflict among them, or one or more are confused or self-undermining, reflection brings these issues to the surface and gets us thinking about how to adjust, modify, or reorganize the goals so that they can be achieved in a consistent way.

Reflection thus both triggers and then furthers thinking about how to achieve the goals I have in the light of the constraints I have (time, money, energy) and their mutual achievability. This thinking is unifying about the goals because they are all *my* goals, and I need to have an integrated and

unifying way of achieving them because I have only one life, the life I am living. What is activated is not thinking in the abstract about types of goal and how they could fit together, but thinking about how *I* can achieve the goals I have in the life I have. It is thinking about my life and how it is going. It is *practical* thinking, thinking about my life and how I should structure it.[6]

Thus the original everyday thinking about the way one thing I do is for the sake of another thing I do leads seamlessly into thinking about my life as a whole in a structured way. This is a *global* way of thinking about my life: I come to see that I have various goals that I aim at, and that in the one life I have, and which I am already living, these goals need to be structured in a *unifying* way in order for me to achieve them. It is also an *active* kind of thinking: the way I organize my goals *shapes* my life and the way I act; it does not just record them. When I think of my actions in the linear way I can just observe the way I am living, but when I think of them in the structured way the result is that I am faced with a *task*, namely, the task of organizing the goals I am working towards, and shaping my life as a whole.

It is this—the idea of what my life as a whole is aimed at—which in ancient ethical theories is called the *telos* or overall goal of life. If we think in a contemporary way about the idea that my life has a goal that it works towards, our response may be that it is implausible that everything I do is a contribution to a single goal or aim. But this is to make a fundamental mistake, namely, to think of the overall aim as something already given in a determinate way, as though I already know that my life is aimed at achieving a specific goal and all I have to do is to work out how to achieve that. This way of thinking of one's life can be found, but only in a very few people, usually those who from an early age have a vocation for art, or politics, or spirituality. Most of us have nothing like this specific grasp of what our lives are working towards achieving. We have only the vaguest idea of what we are aiming for in life as a whole.

This is exactly what eudaimonism holds: we have at best a vague and possibly muddled idea of what our 'final end' is; it is most likely to be only the indeterminate and in itself unhelpful idea of 'a good life' or 'a life lived well'. This supports, rather than undermines, eudaimonism, for few of us have a determinate idea of what we are aiming at in our life as a whole at

[6] It does not conform to the contemporary dogma that the results of thinking can be *either* descriptive *or* normative but never both.

the *start* of ethical reflection. If we did, we would have no need of ethical reflection or theory; our aims would already be clear and the only problems we would have would lie in actually achieving them. What we find in fact is that nearly everyone (every moderately thoughtful person, in any case) is already living a life in which he or she is to some degree actively unifying the aims they have by working out what exactly those aims are and what form they should take. The final end, then, is the indeterminate notion of what I am aiming at in my life as a whole. And the role of ethical thinking is to get us to think more determinately about it, to do a better and more intelligently ordered job of what we are already doing anyway.

Can we say anything more specific about it? At this point Aristotle says that everyone agrees on something more determinate that we can say about it: it is happiness (*eudaimonia*); but that this does not get us a lot further, since people disagree about what happiness is. This is the point at which contemporaries get restive about the notion of happiness; I will return to this, but for the moment I shall make the point that Aristotle is bringing happiness in here merely as the only answer people can give, at the common-sense level, to the questions about why you are doing what you are doing, and how you can have all the goals that you have. That is, at the common-sense level, what is being appealed to is the idea that happiness always puts a stop to these questions. I may want to be healthy, to have a career, to have a family, as part of being happy, but I don't want to be happy as part of or a means to something further. It's just what I want; a terminus to my other goals.

Happiness is, however, still a fairly indeterminate notion, though less so than that of our final end; we can see this from the fact that Aristotle at once goes on to remark that people differ about what makes for happiness not just at the everyday level (some think it's prosperity, others status and fame) but at the theoretical level (some think it is constituted by pleasure, some by virtue). Aristotle himself devotes a large part of his ethical writings to his own answer to the question of what happiness consists in. This answer is dominated by his concern about getting right the relation between what, in a happy life, is up to the agent to develop and what she needs to have as material to work on; arguably it is not as successful an answer as those developed later on by the Stoics and others.[7] Here I am not

[7] For the development of these debates see Annas (1993: pt. IV), and Russell (forthcoming).

concerned with Aristotle's own answer, but with the point that happiness in eudaimonist thinking plays a mediating role between the very vague and indeterminate notion we have of the direction in which our lives are going overall, and specific answers on both the everyday and theoretical levels ('money', 'pleasure', 'virtue', and so on). Happiness is what we all want as a general aim in life, one which brings into focus the unspecific idea of having an overall aim in life, but it is still sufficiently unspecific that people have radically differing views of what it consists in and thus how to go about achieving it.

This role for happiness is extremely useful in ethical theory. At the common-sense level people disagree about what is worth aiming for in life, but all agree that, whether they are going for money-making, fame and fortune, or serving others, they are all aiming for happiness. Happiness thus forms the point at which common sense agrees on a notion which forms the starting-point for ethical theory. Aristotle, the Epicureans, the Stoics, and later Platonist and Christian theories all offer competing hypotheses of what happiness is when you think carefully and rigorously about it. All these theories, however technical, are immediately available to ordinary people as more rigorous answers to questions they ask themselves. Starting to do ethical theory does not require throwing out all or most of everyday thinking about ethics (even though the theories themselves may produce results which are very counter-intuitive). Ethical theory helps us to improve what we are already doing—thinking about how are lives are going and how we can do better.

Of course contemporary eudaimonist theories won't be the same, in structure or in results, as the ancient theories, since, to state the obvious, ethical theories must answer to the concerns of their time and place. However, eudaimonist theories, ancient or contemporary, give happiness the central role of the intersection of everyday ethical thinking and ethical theory. One advantage of this is that we don't find what we do with some ethical theories: just at the point where ethical theory tries to solve the problems whose felt pressure in our concepts and ways of thinking led to the need for theory, it tells us to replace those concepts and ways of thinking with others imported from the theory, whose relevance to our problems is not clear. Eudaimonism does not have this top-down feature.

In eudaimonist thinking we are seeking happiness whether or not we explicitly think to ourselves that we are, because we are all implicitly working out how to adjust our goals, as we live the one life we have.

Happiness has the role of being, for each person, *your* happiness, the way *you* achieve living your life well. It is not some plan imposed on you from outside, or a demand made by some theory which has not arisen from your own thoughts about your life. At the same time it is not just anything you want it to be. There are better and worse ways of seeking happiness, for there are clearly better and worse ways of organizing your goals and aims in life, and of seeking to live a life that achieves them overall.

One important point is that, in the development of the role of happiness as my overall end, the distinction between *my interests* and *the interests of others* is so far irrelevant. Happiness is my overall end because I am, obviously, the one living my life. There is no reason to believe that happiness is my overall end because I either cannot, or will not, take into account the interests or concerns of people other than myself. There is no source in eudaimonist thinking from which to get this idea. (This has not stopped objections that eudaimonism is egoistic; we will return to these in the next chapter.)

Eudaimonism and Happiness

Is happiness in this role in eudaimonist thinking happiness as we understand it?

This issue is sometimes posed as the issue of whether *eudaimonia* is happiness as we understand it.[8] In one respect there is a divergence. Aristotle, and everyone who discusses the issue in the ancient world, treats it as completely obvious and undeniable that we all seek *eudaimonia* in everything we do, and this is not comparably obvious to us with happiness; some people find it obvious, some agree but don't find it obvious, and others deny it. One reason for this is that our idea of happiness is much more determinately specified (often in fairly rigid ways) than happiness in the eudaimonist tradition. Some people, for example, will robustly deny that they seek happiness in everything that they do. They are understanding happiness as an end whose content is already firmly determined, maintaining that while they may seek happiness they also seek other ends as well. It is the prior determinateness of such an end which forms

[8] Sometimes a distinction is drawn between happiness and well-being, but this distinction, at least where it rests on the idea that happiness is 'subjective' and well-being 'objective', does not answer to anything in eudaimonism.

the problem here. It is difficult for us not to feel some influence from this idea, and so it is not just obvious for us now, as it used to be, that happiness is, at a general level, what we are aiming at in everything we do.[9]

This point is not insuperable, however. It is a mistake to remain fixated on the point that happiness often has the role, in contemporary discourse, of an already determinate rather than unspecified end. For a start, we have thoughts about happiness which do line it up with happiness in eudaimonist thinking. Take an everyday dispute about whether a colleague did or did not ruin her life when she lost her job as a result of acting in accordance with her values. (She may have blown the whistle on corrupt practices, say.) One person says that she has ruined her happiness, for now she is unemployable, and all her training and ambition will go to waste. The other person responds that if she had failed to act her life would have been infected with dishonesty and hypocrisy, so that she would never have been happy. This is a substantive dispute about happiness of a recognizable kind. The two disputants are arguing about what their colleague's happiness consists in, and they are both doing so on the assumption that each of them has in mind a different specification of what that is. Does happiness require material prosperity, or is being an honest person more important for being happy? If we all agreed on an account of happiness whose content was already fixed, such discussions would never take place. It would just be obvious, from what happened, whether the person had ruined her happiness or not.

One source of our tendency to assume that the content of happiness must be already fixed is the amount of work done on happiness in the social sciences, work which proceeds on the assumption that it is, for if it were not, it could not be measured, and examined in experiments according to the methodology of those sciences. As it is, large amounts of data have been gathered about happiness by psychologists, economists, and others who are measuring something identified as happiness.[10] I will not

[9] We shall see in the next chapter that it is this assumption about determinateness which lies at the bottom of many of the arguments that claim that happiness must in some way be egoistic as an end.

[10] See The World Database of Happiness, run by Ruut Veenhoven, <http://worlddatabaseofhappiness.eur.nl>, accessed 26 Nov. 2010. Sometimes the methodology of identifying happiness is startlingly unsubtle. See Layard (2005: 6): 'Happiness is feeling good, and misery is feeling bad.' Layard then proposes measuring happiness by tracing people's brain waves (although the 'science' of happiness he has in mind is economics).

here deal with the issue, whether this kind of research has an appropriate grasp of happiness (obviously, on the eudaimonist approach, it hasn't, but this cannot be followed up here). I merely point out here that the notion of happiness employed in the social sciences is not obviously the appropriate one for an individual to use when thinking of his or her own life. In eudaimonist thinking, the entry point for ethical reflection is reflection on how your life is going. However useful, or not, to the social sciences are specific items that can be measured and assessed, this does not seem the appropriate or useful notion of happiness when you are thinking about your own life and how best to live it. The reflection that gets going when each of us thinks about our own life is rather linked to the idea that happiness is something we are already aiming at in a vaguely specified way, and that the task of reflection is to guide us to more specific ways in which we can achieve that.

There is one influential criticism of any account of happiness in eudaimonist thinking. Answering it helps to indicate an important feature of happiness. Grant that we all aim for *something* in our lives overall, vaguely and without being able to specify it beforehand. Grant also that this is happiness, understood as a very general aim which we can achieve in a number of ways. Still, happiness is the point where ordinary thought meets theory: to achieve happiness we have to reflect about what we are doing to achieve it, and how this could be improved. (Assuming that few people think that their lives are, as they stand, completely well-ordered, with well-structured goals.) Different ethical theories offer us different options at this point as to how best to achieve happiness. But this presupposes, as already recognized, that there are better and worse ways to go about achieving happiness, and that different ethical theories are giving us competing answers. But—don't we now find that some people can come up with better answers to this than others? And if so, aren't they in a position to tell other people how to be happy, since the second lot of people would be well advised to listen to what they say? Yet surely it is both intuitively repugnant, and at the level of theory objectionably paternalist, for some people to be in a position to tell others how to be happy. Some philosophers recoil at this point, seeing a spectre emerging from eudaimonism: some people imposing their own vision of the good life on others.

This objection rests on failure to distinguish the circumstances of a life from the living of that life. As we've seen, this is a crucial distinction needed to avoid confusion about the virtues and the way that these are

integrated in a life overall. It is not surprising that we need to keep in mind the same distinction to avoid confusion about happiness in eudaimonist thinking, since this also concerns your life as a whole overall. Some aspects of your life are factors whose existence in your life is not under your control; virtue, as we saw, is not among these, but is to be found rather in the way you live your life, the way you deal with these various factors which you can modify or cope with, but not ignore.

In eudaimonist thinking, happiness is likewise a matter of how you live your life, how you deal with the material of your life. Happiness is not a matter of the stuff you have, or whether you are beautiful, healthy, powerful, or rich. A happy life is not one in which you just have these things—after all, plenty of people have all these things but in no way live happily. A happy life is one in which you deal well with these things that you have—and cope well with illness, poverty, and loss of status, if these things happen to you. Accounts of happiness in this way of thinking are telling us how to live our lives, not urging us either to keep or to change the circumstances of our lives. Thus they are not saying that to have a happy life we need to be healthy, have a lot of money, be educated, or the like. They are telling us that, whatever our circumstances, whether we are healthy or unhealthy, rich or poor, educated or uneducated, we should think about our lives and try to live them well, rather than just continuing on with the way we have hitherto been coping with the circumstances of our lives. It is worth noting that in this they contrast with some recommendations from contemporary theories in the social sciences to the effect that if you want to be happy you would be well advised to be married, go to church, etc. on the grounds that married, churchgoing etc. people are statistically happier than the unmarried and the unchurched. Clearly this confuses the circumstances of a life with the way that life is lived. If you are emotionally unstable, for example, it is usually a very bad idea from the viewpoint of happiness, as well as others, to get married, and probably to become a churchgoer, and an even worse idea to do either *in order to* become happy.

Theories of happiness will correspondingly give us guidance as to how best to live our lives in whatever our circumstances are. A hedonist will tell us that, whether we are rich or poor, educated or uneducated, we should live our lives so as to achieve pleasure from the way we do whatever we do. Aristotle tells us that we should live our lives, whatever these are, virtuously, that is, bravely, temperately, justly, and intelligently; but he

does put some constraints on the circumstances, insisting that we cannot live virtuously in very reduced circumstances. The Stoics deny this, saying that we can live virtuously in any circumstance whatever, however elevated or reduced. These are contrasting views of what we need to do in order to live happily, but none of them force any particular way of life on us (getting married, becoming a churchgoer, etc.) since they are talking about happiness as living your life, not giving us advice about the circumstances of your life. We can follow these theories today just as people could in ancient Greek city-states, the Roman Empire, and Christian, Jewish, and Moslem states in the Middle Ages. It is irrelevant that Aristotle himself, for example, was writing for people in a very specific set of circumstances.[11] Happiness is *active*: it is a matter of how you do whatever it is you do, how you live your life in whatever circumstances you find yourself as you start to reflect about your life. When I start to reflect ethically there is much about my life which I have to recognize as the material I have to work on. The first ethical move is not to abstract from my individual context, still less to discount it, but rather to understand what it consists in, to achieve self-knowledge as far as I can, and then to think about how best to live my life in these circumstances. Only then will I be in a good position to consider the various options offered to me by different ethical theories.

It is clear even from these brief remarks that different theories of happiness in the eudaimonist tradition can take different attitudes to the circumstances of our life. Aristotle thinks that they put constraints on the scope of happiness. Other theories think that they matter, but in different ways. Perhaps good circumstances (money, health, etc.) cannot make us happy in their own right, being in their own right merely so much material; but maybe they can make a good life better? Perhaps they have a different kind of value from the value of living well and being happy? Ancient theories developed these alternatives in rich and sophisticated ways. Contemporary theories are only just beginning to broach these

[11] That Aristotle was teaching elite male Athenian citizens in the fourth century BC tells us about the circumstances of life for and within which he was thinking about happiness. (This explains, for example, why he considers only men, and why he considers some activities that only fairly rich people could do.) It does not, however, determine the way he thinks of happiness, and virtue, in terms of *living your life*, which is why his ethical theory has been found relevant by both women and men in a wide variety of different historical and cultural circumstances.

issues, particularly the issue of whether virtue is necessary or sufficient[12] for happiness. But it is at least clear that it is crucial to draw the distinction between the circumstances and the living of a life if we are to get at all clear about what happiness is, and hence what the relation is between happiness and virtue.

So far I have drawn the outlines of a eudaimonist account without drawing attention to what is an important point about happiness. A happy life is one you enjoy, one you find pleasant, want to continue with, find sustaining. An unhappy life is one in which you are miserable, one you avoid if you can, one in which there is little or no enjoyment. Happiness, in other words, seems to imply some connection with *pleasure*. A eudaimonist account doesn't deny this: as Aristotle says, everyone 'weaves pleasure into' their account of happiness.[13] It is clear, though, that on this account happiness will not turn out just to *be* pleasure, because it can't—pleasure is at the wrong level to be the end unifying all our aims and values. This end, recall, is initially unspecific, and different theories give us guidance how to live by specifying it in different ways. A hedonist will tell us that happiness just is pleasure, so that we will live our lives best by going for pleasure, in some way, in everything that we do. But this is an alternative theory to those that tell us that we should be aiming at a virtuous life, with or without certain constraints. Happiness is the indeterminate end; pleasure is just one suggested specification.

Pleasure and Happiness

Contemporary accounts of happiness often make a different connection between happiness and pleasure, one which has been available only since the late eighteenth century. Happiness on this account is just *identified* with pleasure, where pleasure is understood as a feeling. 'Happiness is feeling good', as the recent author of a book on happiness claims.[14] Happiness is taken to be primarily a matter of having feelings or episodes of feelings, and only secondarily, if at all, a life containing such feelings. This particular way of thinking of happiness has become quite common; when asked if we are happy out of the blue, with no context, we may well first think

[12] Strictly, necessary and sufficient.
[13] *Nicomachean Ethics*, $1153^{b}14$–15.
[14] Layard (2005); see n. 10 above.

about feeling happy, and turn to longer-term ideas of happiness only subsequently. We have acquired a notion of happiness which, far from obviously applying long-term to our lives overall, has come to be associated with short-term episodes or feelings.[15] It is remarkable that this has occurred, and it may be to some extent an accident of history and language; there are languages where there is no single term for both overall happiness and feelings, and even in English the term 'happiness' seems to have been applied to feelings only from the late eighteenth century. It has become part of the way we think about happiness, however, and we have to take account of it.

Could feelings of pleasure be the right kind of item to form the basis of a happy life? This sounds dubious right from the start. It's nice to have feelings of pleasure when eating a good meal, and to enjoy activities such as walking or reading, but these feelings vanish when their object does: the pleasure of eating, and the pleasure taken in walking or reading ceases when the eating, walking, or reading does. This can hardly be what matters to us when we think seriously about how to live our lives.[16] Pleasure is too trivial an item in life to be the most important thing in it, or the goal round which life is organized. Imagine being told of someone that they think that the most important thing in their life is pleasure, and that this is their overriding aim. We would conclude that this was an adult with the mentality of a spoiled 2-year-old, and wonder how they proposed to survive in the real world. (Even spoiled 2-year-olds do not do very well; trying to make a child happy by always aiming to give her pleasure does not in fact succeed in its own terms, as any book on bringing up children will point out.)

Saying anything negative about pleasure is often wrongly thought to indicate puritanism. It is worth meeting this point by reflecting on the role of pleasure in the kind of life we want our children to lead. Suppose I am, *ex hypothesi*, not a puritan, and want my child to lead a happy life. I will want my child to enjoy her activities and have feelings of pleasure. But could this be what makes her life a happy one? This strikes two wrong notes. I will scarcely think that my wish has been granted if my child lives a

[15] In some psychological work 'happiness' is even used for an emotion, on a par with anger, envy, and the like. Presumably it is taken to be a state of feeling good.

[16] I am not dealing with theoretical kinds of hedonism here, but with the appeal, or lack of it, that pleasure has when we are asking about the role of happiness in our lives.

life enjoying activities which are degraded or addictive.[17] And even if an activity is a serious one, something has gone wrong if the person's life is made a happy one not by the activity but by the feelings of enjoyment she gets from it. Any parent would be disconcerted to find that their child had grown up to regard her life as happy because of the enjoyment she got from, say, helping others, but would unhesitatingly drop helping others the minute she ceased to enjoy it. This is, once again, not an adult attitude. And this seems right even before we are in a position to explain *why* something has gone wrong.

One factor helping to explain why it goes wrong is the point that pleasure lacks the right kind of relation to the rest of our moral psychology. This has been called lack of 'causal depth'.[18] If we think of happiness as just feeling good, we cannot, for example, distinguish between the different kinds of impact on a person of unwelcome events. In a revealing example from Daniel Haybron, take two scenarios, in one of which I have pleasant feelings and am feeling good, and then get a flat tyre, while in the other I am feeling good, but then my child dies.[19] If happiness is just having pleasant feelings, the impact of these two events would appear to be the same: first I have pleasant feelings, then I don't, having painful ones instead. Since it is absurd for a theory not to be able to distinguish between these two ways of no longer feeling good, a supporter of pleasure has to say that my loss of pleasant feelings will be much more intense in the second case than in the first. But this plainly fails to give us the right distinction.[20] The real difference lies in the wider impacts and ramifications of the second event; what is bad about it for me is not the intensity of loss of good feeling and occurrence of painful feelings, but the wide and connected effects in all areas of my life of this loss. Nothing like this happens with the flat tyre, which puts a stop to pleasant feeling but without wide or deep impact on my life.

The idea that happiness might just consist in feelings of pleasure or the enjoyment of activities is not very plausible, once we bear in mind the role of happiness as our final end, something in the achieving of which we

[17] Kraut (1979) has influentially made a similar point.

[18] The point, and the term, are from Haybron (2001). See also Haybron (2008: ch. 4).

[19] The example is Haybron's; the idea can be explored with a variety of examples.

[20] As do hedonist moves such as saying that losing a child is losing *more* pleasure than having a flat tyre, the difference being one of degree, not kind.

shape our lives. Pleasure is just not the right kind of item to play this role. It becomes clear that if happiness is construed as feelings of pleasure we have produced a conception of happiness which is not only radically different from the eudaimonist one, but strikingly trivialized.

Happiness and Desires

A more plausible candidate emerges when we follow up the thought that happiness surely has to do with getting what you want, rather than suffering frustration from not getting what you want. This is what seems to matter to young children, for example. We all have desires, and so it can readily seem that the happy person is the person whose desires are fulfilled. Hence the desire-satisfaction kind of account of happiness, a step up from the idea that it is just the having of pleasant feelings.

The desire-satisfaction kind of account appeals to people who are impressed by the fact that we can be happy living very different kinds of life. If we take this seriously, it will seem hopeless to require any particular specific content to the happy life. How can we come up with a content acceptable to everyone? If we think that the happy life must be tranquil we at once think of people happy in lives of physical activity or political engagement; if we think that happiness must require the meeting of challenges we think of the even lives of contemplatives; and so on. The idea that happiness is having your desires fulfilled seems suitably neutral on the content of the happy life; whatever your desires are, if you are getting what you desire you are happy. We've seen, on different grounds, that it is a mistake to try to come up with a single contentful, circumstantial account of happiness to apply to everyone's life, so this may appear a promising idea to develop.

One problem arising at once is that on this account, precisely because of this neutrality, people can be happy if their desires are fulfilled whatever the content of those desires, and some people's desires are evil, or disgusting. Do we really want to call these people happy? We might respond that this is not a problem for the account, since any criticism of these desires will be deflected onto other facts about them (whatever it is about them that renders them evil and/or disgusting), not the point that satisfying them makes us happy. More serious is the point that desires are notoriously malleable. People with low expectations in a certain area of their life, or

even their life as a whole, come to have correspondingly muted desires. The force of social pressure brings it about that many girls come to desire less for themselves than for their brothers, and come to find themselves satisfied by a way of life in which they are valued less, given fewer opportunities, and sometimes even fed less. (This is still true in large parts of the world, if no longer in the West.) When their opportunities are expanded and their expectations raised, they come to be dissatisfied with what previously fulfilled their desires. It is thus notoriously dangerous to rely on the desires that people have at a given time, even when honestly expressed, as indicators of happiness; we should be made uncomfortable by conclusions such as that women in traditional societies, with adjusted modest desires, have less need to be happy than do women in developed societies. Desires can also be manipulated and corrupted in ways that are impossible or at least not easy to reverse, for example by addictions; we are hardly comfortable with the idea that heroin addicts are living happy lives as long as they can get their fix. (Though of course they can have happy *feelings* from time to time in what are usually wrecked and miserable lives.)

Another problem with the desire-satisfaction kind of account is less obvious. We normally get pleasure from the satisfaction of a desire because the desire arises from a perceived need. We enjoy eating when we are hungry, and drinking when we are thirsty. Eating and drinking when we are already satisfied doesn't result in enjoyment; it may be actively unpleasant. In so far as they relate to happiness, then, desires rest on our having needs that are being perceived as needs. We find, then, that a life in which we are happy by having our desires fulfilled is a life in which happiness is built on our having needs that are perceived as needs. And we might wonder if happiness is really linked in this way with *neediness*. This is a point first made by Plato when he describes people seeking happiness by fulfilling desires as constantly trying to fill leaky jars.[21] Humans are, of course, needy creatures; we have natural recurring needs such as hunger and thirst, and as a result of our enculturation we have a number of other needs, such as need for status, money, and so on. Can happiness really just be what we have as we meet these needs? Many of them are bound to recur whatever we do, particularly those that are the least culture-dependent, such as hunger and thirst, and so the leaky jar idea

[21] *Gorgias*, 493d–495b.

starts to sound distressingly apt. If we are to be happy by fulfilling our desires, and these depend on the existence of needs whose nature it is to recur as often as they are met, then trying to be happy appears to be a hopeless task: whatever we do the jar will never get filled.

It can be responded that the problem here is not really human neediness but only the problems we encounter as we try to fulfil our needs. It's not the recurring nature of hunger and thirst which makes them problematic, but the fact that we have to meet these needs from resources that are often scarce and troublesome to find. Further, needs that arise in society, such as needs for money and power, involve competition between people, and are troublesome for that reason, not just because of our neediness itself. To the extent that happiness seems compromised if it rests on neediness, then, this is because of our problems in fulfilling our needs, not the nature of neediness itself.

In a very idealized world, we might think, we could fulfil all our perceived needs without creating any further needs or other problems. Our jar is full of holes, but we could be happy if we could overcome the problems in filling it up; meet our needs, that is, and enjoy doing so, in ways that did not depend on or lead to further neediness. This is an interesting idea, which has influenced some accounts of happiness.

But it turns out to be problematic to remove neediness as an essential aspect of human nature.[22] The author Julian Barnes, in a brilliant piece of writing, brings this point out. In one of his works he describes a man who finds himself in heaven, or rather in 'New Heaven', an up-to-date version of heaven which is non-judgemental, and where you get everything you want, effortlessly and without any adverse consequences. The food is always exactly as you like it, and produces no fullness, indigestion, obesity, or the like. When you play golf, you always win; you excel in any sport or skill you take up.Your favourite soccer teams win; you meet any famous person you like. Your world conforms to what you want it to be, so that all your desires are fulfilled without any of the problems that arise from normal human neediness. What could possibly be the downside to such a life? None appears for a while, but eventually the narrator realizes that he,

[22] When Socrates suggests the idea that a happy life might be one that is not needy, his interlocutor Callicles responds that if that were happiness then stones and corpses would be supremely happy (*Gorgias*, 492e). (This is not the end of the story for Plato, but that would take us far afield.)

and all the other happy people in New Heaven, will ultimately get bored with being able to satisfy any desire they have, with no bad effects, however they ring the changes. And then they will have nothing left to keep them going. When this becomes apparent to a person, he or she willingly goes out of existence. A life of having all your desires fulfilled without the problems created by human neediness leaves humans with nothing to live *for*, nothing to propel them onwards.[23] A life of complete desire-satisfaction, even without the problems involved in having needs, turns out to be essentially backward-looking, and leaves out anything that could get us to move forward with our lives. We recognize, even without any theory about it, that something is deeply lacking in an account of happiness that leaves us nothing to live for once our needs are met in a way that leaves no further neediness.

Happiness and Life-Satisfaction

Not surprisingly, problems with the desire-satisfaction account have led many people studying happiness to a more plausible account, that of *life*-satisfaction. This kind of account takes happiness to be, not a local attitude had when desires are satisfied, but an attitude of global satisfaction with one's life as a whole. This is an improvement on the desire-satisfaction kind of account, since it involves not just a positive feeling but some kind of overall judgement about one's life as a whole, and thus some kind of evaluation of how one's life as a whole is going. If you are studying happiness in the social sciences, this is the obvious item to try to study, since we can ask people what their overall evaluation of their life is, and record answers, whereas asking people about their feelings or whether their desires are satisfied does not lend itself to measurement. Hence we find that, in the social sciences, numerous students of happiness in sociology and psychology departments study self-reports of life satisfaction, and

[23] Barnes (1989: ch. 10). The narrator is someone with very simple and basic desires, and so comes to the point of 'deciding that he's had enough' quite soon. People with more complex wants last longer. Gratifyingly for intellectuals, these are lawyers and scholarly people who 'like sitting around reading all the books there are. And then they love arguing about them' (p. 304). (The people who actually write the books don't last as long.) Still, eventually everyone has had enough of getting what they want, and with nothing else to live for, they go out of existence. A related idea is treated in Janáček's opera *The Makropoulos Case*, on which see Williams (1973).

this often leads to the assumption that life satisfaction is just what happiness is. This is the assumption behind the World Database of Happiness, which over a period of twenty years has amassed the results of questionnaires on life satisfaction and come up with numerous conclusions about happiness both in and between different nations.[24]

There are obvious problems with this approach. One is that people can be expected to have a variety of views as to what it is to be satisfied with their lives. Some may respond that they have an affirmative attitude to their life as a whole because they have attained their major goals in life, even though emotionally they feel flat or even distressed. Others may respond affirmatively about their lives because they are feeling happy at the time they are asked, even though they have failed to attain, or lost, the things they have spent their lives attaining. Some may think that individual achievement matters for being positive about one's life; others may value family ties and connections more. It is thus quite unclear that people asked at a given time about satisfaction with their lives are answering the same question; and this obviously renders uncertain what is achieved by collecting the answers. In several forms of questionnaire, for example, subjects are asked to answer the question as to how happy their life is (where this is taken to be a measure of life satisfaction) by picking a face on a single line of simplified faces from very smiley to very frowning. Some may be picking the face that corresponds to the way they feel at the moment; others may be picking the face that corresponds best to the way they think their life is going in terms of actually achieving their goals. Interestingly, it is completely unclear how subjects are supposed to pick a face on a single scale when two or more ways in which they think of their life as satisfactory conflict. For example: I have achieved my life's goals, but my family has just been killed in an accident. Or: I have achieved my life's goals, but in ways that I now regret and leave me miserable about them. Or: I have never achieved much of what I aimed at, but late in life have found a warm family life. In this kind of case no answer can be right: neither picking the face at either end nor picking the one in the middle, as though you could split the difference between these kinds of factor.

Not only are there these problems about a person's response at a given time, we might also wonder how we are supposed to take into account the

[24] See n. 10 above.

fact that our estimations of how our lives are going tend to change in various ways. They change over time. As I struggle unsuccessfully as a young architect, with unfulfilled commissions, I rate my life negatively; in later years I may rate it more positively, either because I got commissions or because I came to terms with the fact that I had limited talent or bad luck. They also alter in response to taking different perspectives. On a weekday I might rate my life negatively because of the stress my work involves. On a weekend I might rate it more positively, and again for a variety of reasons. I may now appreciate the material goods my job enables me to get. Or I might appreciate the contrast between weekend leisure and weekday work. Or I might go to church or synagogue and appreciate the wider view of my life I get there.

Thus, although I am taking a view of how positive or negative my attitude is to my life as a whole, I am necessarily taking this view from a particular perspective, which is of course influenced by where, in my life, I am, and the many factors that hence come to be salient. This is an obvious enough point, but important to bear in mind when considering the use made of life-satisfaction questionnaires in the social sciences, and the kind of conclusions that can reasonably be drawn from them.[25] And it is even more important when considering the usefulness of life-satisfaction surveys for the question of what happiness is. The many ways in which answers to questions about life-satisfaction can vary, depending on the person's position in their life-narrative, the importance they attach to different factors in their lives, and the adoption of different perspectives, show that if we were to take life-satisfaction accounts to be accounts of happiness, we would have to conclude that a person's happiness, the positive or negative attitude they have to their lives, varies over time and depends on which factors the person thinks important, and which perspectives (not to mention pressures of various kinds) are salient and important to them at the moment. But clearly we are not entitled to conclude this. What we can conclude is that people's *opinions about their happiness* vary over time and according to the factors that are important to

[25] One example of such a use made of the World Database of Happiness (which I remember from a conference) was a claim that people think that having children will make their lives happier, but are not in fact made happier by having children. No account was apparently taken of the age of the children when the second report was made. Of course parents of small children will typically report that their lives have worsened in many ways; the outlook is very different years later.

them at the time. But this is not news. It was not news to Aristotle: '[T]he masses think [happiness] is something straightforward and obvious, like pleasure, wealth or honour, some thinking it to be one thing, others another. Often the same person can give different accounts: when he is ill, it is health, when he is poor, it is wealth.'[26] People have varied, shifting, and often confused ideas about what happiness consists in. This does not show that happiness itself is varied, shifting, or confused.

We should notice that evaluation of your life as a whole may tell us a lot about the person doing the evaluating, and in this respect prove useful for studying the evaluation side, as it were. Recent studies in the area of mental health have discovered the limits of self-report about how people are feeling about their lives, reports which track their feelings of pleasure; but this has indicated the importance of a different kind of self-report, namely reporting on how you are *functioning* in life. Corey Keyes, who has pioneered this kind of study, has shown how this distinguishes between people who are *flourishing*, in his terminology, and people who are *languishing*. Flourishing and languishing are overall conditions of effective or ineffective functioning, which correlate in a surprisingly weak way with absence or presence of mental illness.[27] Studies of flourishing and languishing indicate how important it is for us that we take seriously our overall assessment of how well we are functioning in life, in whatever our cultural and social context is, and not just how we feel about our life. The former, but not the latter, holds out some hope for helpful social policies directed at happiness.

Subjective and Objective

This kind of flourishing, in terms of good functioning in various areas of your life, obviously has a great deal in common with the notion of happiness that we find in eudaimonism; whether you have a positive attitude to your life is surely part of, or at very least relevant to, the issue of whether you are happy. There are dangers, however, in taking any

[26] *Nicomachean Ethics*, 1095ª22–5.

[27] See e.g. Keyes (2007). Traditional psychology has paid little or no attention to such overall states, focusing more on specific types of mental illness, and has also overwhelmingly focused on psychological problems and defects, rather than on ways in which we can encourage positive conditions. On this conception of flourishing and Aristotle see Keyes and Annas (2009).

positive attitude, even one more complex than feeling good, to be what happiness is, at least as we are concerned with happiness in eudaimonist thinking. A positive attitude—approving, feeling positive about, endorsing, and so on, your life—depends on me, and so it depends on me whether I am happy, since it depends on me, and the condition I am in, whether I approve, feel positive, endorse, and so on, my life. I can be wrong about important features of my life, but if I approve, feel positive, endorse it, then on this view I am happy. The point here can be well brought out by an example.[28] Susan thinks of her life as a happy one; she is married with children, and all is well except that her husband is frequently away on business. She discovers that in fact these absences were spent with a second family, and that he has divided his time between the two families for some years. Uncontroversially, Susan evaluated her life positively before the discovery, and no longer did so after the discovery. The question is: before the discovery, was her life happy or not? If positive evaluation of your life is what happiness is, then Susan had a happy life until the discovery. But this runs into the problem that we are also inclined to say that after the discovery Susan discovered that her life never was a happy one; she was deceived into thinking that it was. Our responses are divided: we see the force of the point that her life was not a happy one even when she wrongly thought it was, and also the force of the point that her own attitude to her life is important for her positive evaluation of it. At any rate, we do not have unambiguous responses to the effect that Susan is happy just when she thinks she is.

In modern debates this is often seen as a conflict between 'subjective' and 'objective' views of happiness. The terms 'subjective' and 'objective' are used in very many different ways, some of which are defined in terms of specific theories, but here we need consider them only in relation to the different responses to the Susan example and others like it. The view that happiness is a positive evaluation of your life turns out to be, in these terms, a subjective theory of what happiness is: Susan is happy if and when she thinks she is, so she is happy during all the years her husband was deceiving her and their children. If this sounds wrong, as it does to many people, it may appear that there is a straightforward alternative: an objective theory. On an objective theory of what happiness is, Susan is not happy once her

[28] The example is from Sumner (2003). I have frequently used it in classes, and found that response to it is generally divided.

husband starts producing another family and lying to her about it, whether she knows about it or not. This gives us what many see as the acceptable answer about Susan, and it matches a number of our other intuitions also.

If we accept an objective theory in these terms (taken from our responses to the Susan story) we seem to get into difficulties too. It's obvious what is wrong with Susan's situation, but once we accept that you can be unhappy even though you think you are happy, we face the task of coming up with a systematic account of what things count as making someone happy rather than unhappy when they think they are happy; and so we are led to find a list of things you need to have, or aspects of your life that need to go well, for you to be happy regardless of the way you feel. This is sometimes called an 'objective list' theory. And attempts to come up with such a list are doomed to failure, for they are all liable to convincing counterexamples. We might think that nobody can be happy if they are chronically ill or desperately poor, but we can find examples of lives lived in these conditions which it would be unreasonable not to call happy. If we insist that people can't be happy if they are ill, or poor, we at once seem to be imposing on their lives requirements that the healthy and prosperous take to be necessary; but why are we privileged in our accounts of happiness just because we happen to be healthy and/or prosperous?

Moreover, another kind of problem looms. It sounds plausible to say that to be happy people need health, energy, good attachments, and the like; but what of the person who *rejects* one or more of these but none the less consistently claims to be happy? Some people have rejected prosperous lifestyles and even put their health at risk in order to live lives they find worthwhile; again, it is far from obvious that the prosperous and healthy are right when they say that such lives can't be happy. It soon emerges, then, that we can find convincing counterexamples to both the subjective and the objective accounts of happiness.[29]

This very fact, though, is an indication that we have a false choice here, and that it would be unpromising to follow up either alternative. We have, as Aristotle would put it, ended up in *aporia*; we seem to have to choose

[29] To repeat: I am not canvassing the literature on subjective and objective accounts, which would require going further than I can in the present work into the many different distinctions coming under these terms. I am simply dealing with responses to the Susan story, which does divide people between views of happiness, views which they often characterize as subjective and objective.

between two alternatives, but not only are both unacceptable, we have run out of resources for solving the problem as long as we stay within the terms of debate which presented us with these alternatives. This strongly suggests that this whole approach to thinking of happiness is systematically unpromising.

Eudaimonism Again

I have indicated the kind of thing which goes wrong with accounts of happiness as feelings of pleasure, having your desires satisfied and having a positive evaluation of your life. The first two have been the objects of much academic philosophical discussion, but have not been rescued from the objections of principle I mention here. The third is more prominent in the social sciences; it has also recently been discussed by Haybron.[30] Contemporary discussions of happiness focus on these three alternatives (outside philosophy, some of the authors seem unaware even that there are these alternatives). Even the most subtle of them, the third, ends up unable to make progress beyond a dilemma that it lacks the resources to reject.

This does not amount, of course, to a complete argument in favour of a eudaimonist account, but it does lay out the main lines on which such an argument will have to go. Contemporary discussions of happiness often start from the idea that happiness just is having pleasant feelings or getting what you want, or having a positive attitude to your life overall, sometimes without being aware that there is anything problematic in any of these conceptions, or that they are very different conceptions, or that there is a powerful alternative in the eudaimonist conception of happiness. Happiness in eudaimonist thinking does not exclude pleasure, but it excludes the idea that happiness could just *be* pleasure. It answers to our thoughts that happiness must in some way have pleasures 'woven into it', as Aristotle says, as something which is involved in it and not just accidentally attached,[31] but makes it clear that pleasure is the wrong kind of item to be happiness—unless we become convinced by hedonist arguments. But

[30] Haybron (2008). Haybron's own account, though rich and sophisticated, does not escape the problems of a 'feelings' account. See Lebar and Russell (forthcoming).

[31] Aristotle's other interesting metaphor for the relation of pleasure and happiness is that happiness does not bring along pleasure just as a removable attachment, like a necklace (probably with an amulet) hung round the neck (*Nicomachean Ethics*, 1099^{a}15–16).

in this framework hedonists have a hard time convincing people that happiness could just be constituted by pleasure, since in a eudaimonistic framework this requires both allowing that happiness is less active than we conceive it as being, and also reconfiguring the idea of pleasure in quite extreme ways till we can think of it as an overall end for our lives.[32]

Happiness in a eudaimonist account is what I come to when I start asking about my life, how it is going and how I can achieve better. Happiness is *my* happiness, the way *I* live my life; only I can achieve my happiness, because only I can live my life, and happiness won't result from some plan imposed on me from outside my own reflections. This answers to some of the thoughts behind contemporary insistence that happiness is 'subjective'. However, it is not exposed to many of the objections raised against such 'subjective' theories. Happiness on this account is not a matter of my feelings, or something to be achieved without reference to other people. We are all seeking happiness, explicitly or not, because we are all working on our lives; there is more to achieving happiness than just feeling a certain way, or getting what you want, and there are better and worse ways of living your life. Happiness in a eudaimonist account answers in these ways to some of the thoughts behind contemporary 'objective' accounts of happiness. However, it is not exposed to many objections to these accounts; it does not require a list of objectively valuable components of a life, and is not committed to the idea that we can give one-size-fits-all requirements for everyone to live a happy life.[33] This account of happiness thus does justice to considerations which have led many to think that happiness must be either 'subjective' or 'objective', while not getting committed to the view that we must take one of these options and that they form a dilemma; as we've seen, this leads to a dead end.

Having argued for an account of virtue, I have now argued for an account of happiness. In both cases there are alternatives, both ancient and modern, and I have done no more than bring out the strengths of the

[32] In the ancient world the hedonist Epicurus is notorious both for having a final end which is too 'passive' (since it is pleasure) and for insisting that in so far as it can form our happiness pleasure has to be thought of as tranquillity, a move generally found to be forced. See Annas (1993: chs. 7, 11 s. 2, and 16). Mill's struggles to find a place for virtue and the *telos* in a utilitarian framework are well known.

[33] These would turn out to be rather one-size-fits-none, since we have already seen that the circumstances of people's lives are so diverse that there is not going to be a single way of living which deals well with all of them.

views I defend. This would be of little interest if either of these accounts were ones that are alien to us, but by this point I hope that this is not the case for either of them. The account of virtue has emerged from everyday thoughts about reasoning and acting. The account of happiness has emerged from reflecting on a conception of happiness which is now only one of the conceptions of happiness that we have. The recent resurgence of eudaimonist versions of virtue ethics indicates that it is readily available for our thoughts and deliberations.[34] The problem is rather to give a proper place in it to pleasure, while distinguishing it from the view identifying happiness with pleasure which we have inherited from the late eighteenth century. The accounts both of virtue and of happiness will be further filled out in the next chapter, which discusses their relationship.

[34] Anecdotally: my own experience in teaching over many years is that eudaimonism strikes most people as a natural and obvious way to think about their lives, and that when introduced to it as an option in ethical theory they frequently find it both more powerful and more plausible than consequentialism and/or deontology.

9

Living Virtuously, Living Happily

Virtue and Happiness

It will be no surprise that the account of virtue and the account of happiness presented here enable us to make good sense of the idea that living virtuously is a good way of living happily, even perhaps the only way. It is not meant to be a surprise at this stage; a large part of the point of this work is to show how these accounts of virtue and happiness fit together.

Is virtue even a starter as a candidate for making you happy? By now it's obvious that the answer is: probably not, on contemporary accounts of happiness as feeling good, getting what you want, and feeling satisfied with your life. But we've seen that we don't have to think of happiness this way. If happiness is the overall end you aim to achieve by living your life well, then virtue does look like a very obvious starter, for it looks like a better idea to be loyal and sincere than to be disloyal and deceptive. It is absurd to think that we really have no more reason to acquire the virtues than not when we are thinking about how best to live. Rosalind Hursthouse has made the point forcefully:[1] we want our children to grow up honest and brave, rather than shifty and cowardly, and we bring them up to have these virtues (as far as we can) not just for our own sake, in order to be able to rely on them in pursuing our own interests, but for their sake, because we think that they will live better lives being honest and brave rather than being shifty and cowardly.

When we are thinking of a happy life, then, it is just common sense that we want ourselves and our children to have the virtues. This doesn't show

[1] Hursthouse (1999*a*: 174–6).

that the virtues are either necessary, or sufficient, for living happily, but it does show that we think that it is, at weakest, reasonably to be expected that living virtuously will in at least in part constitute living happily. We need further argument to convince us of stronger claims such as necessity or sufficiency, but this is reasonable, and in tune with many ordinary responses to changes in circumstances. We reject bringing our children up to be vicious, but when bad things happen to a good person our reactions tend to be confused. Has the person lost their happiness when they suddenly lose all their money, or their house, or their health? Or does their happiness depend on the ways in which they can cope, or not, with these losses? Our intuitions go both ways, and we struggle in the way that Aristotle does between the thought that bad enough changes of circumstances can affect happiness, and the thought that even bad circumstances don't themselves compel you; it's always up to you to deal well with bad situations.[2]

I am not in this work arguing that virtue is necessary (or sufficient) for a happy life. More modestly here, I am showing how, given the present accounts of virtue and of happiness, these issues arise naturally as issues of philosophical argument from the ways we think about our lives. They are not, as they appear on some rival accounts, alien imports from high-minded theory that we can barely make sense of.

The intuitive place to start is the ordinary, commonplace assumption that a person's life will, to put it generally, *go better* if they have the virtues—if they are generous and brave, for example—than if they don't. Before reflecting on any of these issues, we want to be talented, beautiful, successful—and also to be good people: loyal, honest, dependable. We get this far before we even raise the issue of the kind of value the virtues have in relation to other factors such as beauty and success. Does this kind of thinking reasonably fit thoughts about *happiness*?

Here, as emphasized, we moderns have come to have a problematic conception of happiness. On the one hand, we think of it as an overall end to be achieved in living a happy life, and to this extent we can make ready sense of the idea that living a good life is a way of living a happy life. It at once becomes natural to argue whether it is the best way of doing so, or

[2] *NE* I. 8–10 ($1098^{b}9$–$1101^{a}21$). Aristotle uses evocative metaphors: the good person in difficulties will be like the general making the best use of the troops he has, and the shoemaker making the best shoes he can out of the leather that he has.

perhaps the only way, or whether it is merely one way, and perhaps not even reliable. These arguments all develop within the assumption that living virtuously is, intuitively, a way of living happily, where that is not itself something that needs to be argued for.

But on the other hand we also have another, more passive notion of happiness—the more recent idea that happiness is pleasant feeling, or getting what you want, or being satisfied with your life. Apart from the internal problems that each of these recent conceptions of happiness brings with it (problems we have looked at) they all make it difficult to think of virtue as even a starter candidate for either contributing to, or constituting, the happy life. The pleasure-view of happiness brings this about in several ways. First, feelings of pleasure and states of desire-satisfaction and life-satisfaction are all determinate states of the person. At any given time I have feelings of pleasure (or not) and am in a state of having my desires satisfied (or not) or being satisfied with my life (or not). On this view, how can my having the disposition to be brave, or loyal, contribute to my having these feelings or being in this state? Perhaps the answer is that it does so by way of the brave and loyal actions I perform, brave and loyal thoughts I have, and so on. But the mystery does not lessen: how do virtuous actions and thoughts lead to my having feelings of pleasure, or being in a satisfied state, any more than virtuous dispositions do? On this view, we are forced into making large and unconvincing assumptions, such as the assumption that virtuous actions will predictably put me in a position to have feelings of pleasure, or states of satisfaction. Small surprise that philosophers who think of happiness this way have generally had little to do with virtue, thinking of it as alien to their framework and likely to import implausible claims.

Thinking of happiness as feelings of pleasure or states of satisfaction imports another problem: pleasure is a static way of thinking about something essentially dynamic. Thinking of my life in terms of being pleased or getting what I want is, as we have seen in the last chapter, essentially a backward-looking way of thinking about it; there is nothing in these accounts answering to the central point that happiness is forward-looking, an *aim* we have that propels us forward. As ancient authors point out, it doesn't make sense to ask why you aim to be happy, in the way it certainly makes sense to ask why you aim to have pleasant feelings or to have desires satisfied, rather than choosing to have some other aims. Living happily is essentially an overall *aim*, in eudaimonist thinking, and this gives

it the right place in our lives. Living happily is not feeling good, getting what you want, or feeling satisfied with your life. How could any of these serve as an aim, inspire you to *do* anything? When we aim at living happily we are aiming at going forward in certain ways, getting somewhere in what we are doing. Hence the static conception of happiness which takes it to be pleasure is ill situated to make sense of any connection with virtue, which is itself essentially dynamic and forward-looking. Again, it is no surprise that philosophers with a static conception of happiness have seen little connection of that with virtue. Why ever would becoming a virtuous person, aiming at doing virtuous actions (for the right kinds of reason and with the right kinds of attitude) land you in a state of pleasant feeling?

Possibly the most significant problem about virtue's relation to happiness imported by thinking of the latter in terms of pleasant feelings or satisfaction is that it leads us to confuse the circumstances of a life with the living of it. We have seen this confusion with virtue;[3] but it happens with happiness too. Feeling pleased is essentially a passive part of my life. I can be active in bringing it about: eating appropriate food when hungry, engaging in activities that appeal to me. But feeling pleased, like any feeling, is not itself part of the way I live my life. As with other circumstances of my life, it is not up to me whether feelings of pleasure or satisfaction come from experiences, including the satisfaction of desires; it is only up to me to manage this in so far as I can. Pleasure thought of as feeling or satisfaction is essentially passive, part of the materials making up my life but hardly part of actively living it. Hence pleasant feelings or satisfaction come to be thought of, on a 'feelings' view of happiness, as episodes in my life. But then they are just part of the circumstances of my life. Aiming at pleasure, understood as a way of living my life, will come, on this view, to nothing more than manipulating other circumstances so that I get as many of these episodes as I can.

If we think of happiness this way we will see no plausible connection with virtue. Indeed, *virtue* comes to be seen as just one item in the life I am leading, with nothing to encourage me even to see it as crucial in my life. This is perhaps the position some people find themselves in who want to be good, but also want to be rich and successful, and then ask why virtue should be a more important item in their lives than money or success.

[3] See the end of Ch. 6.

If we are not clear that virtue is part of the living of my life, rather than the circumstances of it, we will be hard put to it to find any reason for systematically preferring virtue to pleasure (or, come to that, pleasure to virtue) as we live our lives. The decision between them will come to appear a matter of personal preference, or even arbitrary. I prefer virtue to pleasure; you prefer the opposite. This fails to take virtue seriously, and shows the importance of being clear about the distinction between the circumstances and the living of a life.

On the eudaimonist approach, none of these problems arise. Neither virtue nor happiness is a matter of the circumstances of my life. (This is consistent with the point that that these circumstances might put constraints on happiness.) Both living virtuously and living happily are ways of living my life, dealing with the materials I have to hand, making the best of the life I have led up to now. Problems about their relation are problems as to the relations between ways of living my life. If I ask, about my life, how best I can live happily from now on, this is a practical question, to which answers will take the form: living honestly, say, or living dishonestly. Which I choose will make a difference to whether I live happily; it will make a difference, for example, to how I earn my living. 'Earning my living' is not itself an answer to how best to live happily: earning a living is part of the material to be given a shape by honesty or dishonesty. Moreover, happiness, taken as living happily is clearly an ongoing activity, not a static condition to be achieved and then rested in. And happiness as living happily is not a determinate, any more than a static condition. Virtue doesn't makes me happy by getting me to an already clearly defined goal, as I might be given feelings of pleasure by winning a game or a prize.

How then does it make me happy? At any given time in my life I already have a life; I am living the life I have, which presents itself to me in large part formed by the way I have already lived it, given the circumstances of my life. How I live my life is greatly due to my character, the way I am dispositionally, my tendencies to act, reason, and feel in various areas of life in accordance with the values I have. Since life is always ongoing and we are always developing in various ways, both as a result of reflection and in response to changing factors in our circumstances, my character is not fixed; I am always maintaining the way I am, whether sustaining or protecting formed dispositions or actively trying to change myself in some respect. How I progess, or regress, to or away from being a virtuous person will depend on a number of factors: for example, the way

I was brought up and the extent to which I have reflectively gone along with that and built on it, or rejected or modified its effects in myself; the frequency and depth with which I examine myself and ask about the way I am living; the extent to which my ways of thinking about myself and others are infused with either theory or more imaginative and empirical reasoning, or all of them. Although I have not emphasized it, an important part of how I think about myself will come from how I have responded to books, movies, and the like as well as more intellectual fare.

The virtues, as we've seen, are a matter of character: the different virtues (and vices!) make up my character in various areas of life. Happiness, on a eudaimonist view, is the way I live my life overall. In any life there will, then, always be a dynamic interplay between the virtues (or vices!) and happiness. Whether I live happily will depend at least in part on the dispositions I have developed as I have lived my life, the way these are maintained or decay, and their mutual interrelations. Our intuitive view of our lives takes this much for granted; it's then a matter of philosophical argument *how* important these dispositions are for the living of a happy life.

What, after all, is the alternative? How could it be just the circumstances of our lives that make us happy, or not? How can stuff make you happy? As we constantly discover, a big house, a car, money, holidays, don't make us happy if we cannot make the right use of them in our lives. On their own they do nothing for us; how can they? A shop flyer I saw gets *something* right: 'Money doesn't make you happy—shopping does.' Stuff is irrelevant for happiness until you *do* something with it, even shopping.

This much is true of any reasonable account of happiness, though the point tends to be ignored by 'happiness studies' which tell us that we are more likely to be happy if we have money, education, a spouse, and so on, as though this could possibly be advice for everyone to follow.[4] Given that so much in contemporary work on happiness searches for happiness in the circumstances of our lives, it bears repeating that money, health, beauty,

[4] Myers (1992: 206–7) lists things that 'enable happiness': 'fit and healthy bodies, realistic goals and aspirations, positive self-esteem, feelings of control, optimism, outgoingness, supportive friendships that enable companionship and confiding, a socially intimate, sexually warm, equitable marriage, challenging work and active leisure, punctuated by adequate rest and retreat, a faith that entails communal support, purpose, acceptance, outward focus and hope.' Myers adds that his book is 'like *Consumer Reports*', which gives us useful information when making choices; we are envisioned as picking from the list of approved items to suit our own choices about happiness.

even relationships don't make us happy; our happiness comes at least in part from the way we do or don't actively live our lives, doing something with them or acting in relation to them. Happiness is at least in part *activity*. If we fully take this on board, putting the feel-good accounts of happiness on one side, it becomes clearer why what makes us happy couldn't just be stuff sitting there in our lives, or passive states of feeling or satisfaction. To live happily we require something with as much dynamism and internal drive as happiness itself has, and the virtues provide this.

Happiness and Egoism

Any eudaimonist account of virtue has to meet the challenge of showing that eudaimonism is not committed to egoism.[5] This is a charge which comes in several philosophical variations, but they all answer to an intuitive worry that we contemporaries feel, though it has no traction in traditions in which eudaimonism is central. We have come to have a vague feeling that morality, or ethics, is essentially about the interests and concerns of others, and that concern with myself, whatever form it may take, can't be moral or ethical. Since the virtuous person, in a eudaimonist account, is concerned with making herself a virtuous person, this can alert the vague feeling that something must be wrong about the whole idea. It is beyond the scope of this work to get to the roots of this vague feeling and the way we have retained it from a tradition in which morality has been assumed to have a form into which eudaimonism does not fit.[6] Here I will merely take on specific objections to accounts of virtue in a eudaimonist framework, on the grounds that virtue is here egoistic. The relevant construal of egoism here is ethical egoism, the idea that my own good is the source of my reasons for what is right for me to do, the dispositions I should have and the kind of person I should be.

These objections do not hold for consequentialist accounts of virtue, where what makes a trait a virtue are the good consequences it systematically

[5] Egoistic forms of eudaimonism are of course possible (Epicurus, for example), but eudaimonism is not as such egoistic.

[6] Since MacIntyre (1985) it has been clear that the ethical options open to us have increased since the late twentieth century. (This is partly due to increased awareness of the history of ethics.) There has been less awareness of this than there should be in metaethics, where theories featuring virtue and happiness are still often misunderstood and forced into anachronistic moulds.

produces; these are obviously indifferent to my attitude to my and others' concerns, since they depend on the state of the world independent of me, and might benefit me or others indifferently. Nor do they hold for pluralist accounts of virtue, in which I should cultivate the virtues because they are valuable, and further various values, in a number of ways which cannot be reduced to a single one. In these accounts, living virtuously is cultivating the various virtues, but without the claim that this will *benefit* me. Indeed, although living virtuously will be living admirably, there is no inner drive in the theory to take this to be living happily. Thinkers such as Nietzsche, who take the virtues to lead to conflict and disturbance in a single life, are (as we saw in the quotation at the start of Ch. 8) quite scornful of the suggestion that living according to the virtues might benefit you, make you happy, or even lead to your advantage. If we accept this thought, we might conclude that we should live virtuously and accept that it will not make us happy; or we might take the more Nietzschean path and reject the whole idea of seeking happiness as a pathetic aim anyway.

Eudaimonist accounts of virtue do, however, face the egoism objection. For living virtuously is valuable, it seems, because it will constitute, in part, my happiness; isn't this selfish? Even when we clear the ground and make it patent that my happiness is not pleasure but *eudaimonia*, my final end, this does not get rid of the point. This is *my* final end, not yours, so it looks as though it is my good (interests, concerns) which gives me reasons for my acquisition and exercise of the virtues. (Henceforth in this argument I will just refer to happiness.)

Two mistaken views of the objection, and meeting them, will help clear the ground further. It might be thought that if my reason for having the virtues is that they will benefit me, then I will act on the wrong reasons, for I will be favouring my own interests, and I will have the wrong kind of motivation for acting. Both charges fail to take into account that this is an account of *virtues*, not traits which bend to fit the aims of the person who has acquired and exercised them. Someone acting for reasons of self-interest, or only out of self-interest, is not virtuous. The egoism charge is focused rather on the person who genuinely has the virtues, and also thinks in a eudaimonist framework, and the aim is to show that there are internal problems in this combination. The basic charge is that if a person has developed the virtues and thinks in virtuous ways, and also thinks that living virtuously is, even in part, constitutive of her happiness, then her

reasons for acting, feeling, and so in, in virtuous ways, will ultimately come from, and be motivated by, concern for her happiness. And this is egoistic, however virtuous the person.

A familiar way of putting this objection, in part because of a well-known proponent of it, is in terms of the claim that such an account of virtue is 'foundationally egoistic'. Happiness in a eudaimonistic theory is said to be the 'foundation' or 'basis' for virtuous motivation, which is 'derived from' it and 'defined in terms of it'.[7] Such attacks fail against an account like the present one, which is avowedly not foundational but holistic; they are imposing a Procrustean framework on accounts like the present one.

This point does not dispose of the objection, however. Even if happiness is not foundational in the account, you might still be disconcerted to find that your reasons and motivation for acting virtuously and acquiring and exercising the virtues come from concern for your happiness (even if not 'derived' from it). Surely, you might think, your reasons for acting virtuously and being virtuous come from what you were taught they came from: this is the best way to act, and to be, in this area of your life.Virtue involves a commitment to goodness because it is goodness. And surely your happiness is a different concern from this. This gets the worry going even for people who do not already accept a 'foundational' framework for ethics and who do not think that any eudaimonist account of virtue must squeeze into a framework where one part of the theory is 'derived' from another.[8]

The alleged objection, as articulated by contemporary critics, goes thus. If the account is eudaimonist, then happiness must be one's overall aim in living. And if the account is a virtue-centred account, then one is also aiming to be living virtuously. But one has to give some account of how these two aims fit together. In acting virtuously and aiming to become a virtuous person, my reasons for doing this are either aimed at achieving happiness or not. But either option is troublesome. However worthy may be my aim of acting virtuously and becoming a virtuous person (worthy as opposed to an aim of having a good time, or getting rich), I am still aiming

[7] Cf. Hurka (2001: ch. 8). I have criticized this aspect of Hurka's attack, and some other points of his, at greater length in Annas (2007).

[8] There is also the assumption, in Hurka and many others, that any ethical theory will produce some kind of decision procedure telling everyone what to do. See Ch. 3.

at *my happiness*. And this, it is claimed, is inconsistent with a proper account of virtue; virtue implies a commitment to the good, and whatever account we give of what the good is, if I am virtuous my good surely can't be my own happiness. So it looks as though I am driven to say that in acting virtuously and aiming to become virtuous I am not aiming at achieving my own happiness. I am aiming at the proper aim of the virtuous, which is the good (whatever account we give of that). But then is the account any longer eudaimonist? It seems that it could only be so if eudaimonism were what is now called a self-effacing theory—that is, a theory which tells us to achieve the aim of the theory not by aiming at it but precisely by *not* aiming at it, by not doing what it bids and by not becoming the kind of person it recommends, but doing, and aiming at being, something entirely different.

The first horn of the alleged dilemma first: acting virtuously and being a good person is not being focused on yourself—yet the eudaimonist virtuous person's reasons for acting virtuously and becoming a virtuous person do have reference to her own happiness. We can by now see that this charge loses any force it appeared to have as soon as we clarify what happiness is here. Critics often assume that the only viable conceptions of happiness must be of the pleasure or desire- or life-satisfaction kinds, and clearly any of these would create a problem for the virtuous person. On this view, the objection fails as soon as we point out the difference between such conceptions and happiness in eudaimonist thinking.

At this point, though, the objection can be reformulated: even if happiness can be thought of as flourishing, for example, it's still an end that virtue appears to be a means to attaining, and virtue still seems threatened with merely instrumental status. This can be rejected when we recall that happiness is not an end which is defined or characterized in a circumstantial way—that is, in terms of specific circumstances—independently of virtue. The objection holds only against people who hold that being virtuous is a good (or possibly the best) way of achieving happiness where happiness is *already* defined in a determinate and circumstantial way independently of whether you are virtuous or not. Examples of such definitions might be: having a successful career, making lots of money, being a movie star, and the like. But it is so obvious that virtue is not a good, still less the best, way of achieving ends like these that as an actual position this would be hard to find, held only by naive people (before they become disillusioned).

Happiness in eudaimonist thinking, as we have seen in Ch. 8, is not this kind of end at all, and there is actually no excuse for thinking that it is, since we have a two-thousand-year tradition of kinds of eudaimonist theories none of which take this form.[9] Happiness is the unspecific overall aim that we find that we have in mind in some form in what we are doing. What we take it determinately to consist in is not given in advance of our becoming virtuous. (If it is, then becoming virtuous is likely to change it, as someone might be brought up to think happiness simply consists in being rich, but alters this view as he becomes a better person.) Our final end *becomes* more determinate as we live and develop our characters. It is as we develop our characters that we come to form our views that happiness is being a good person with a reasonable level of material goods, or just being a good person, or perhaps that it is just having a good time, or being rich or famous. Virtue cannot be assessed as a means to an already agreed-upon and determinately formed end.

A last gasp form of this objection takes it that virtue must be a means to happiness as a determinate and circumstantial end because happiness, whatever we take it to consist in, is a state of the agent. This fails because, as we have seen, happiness is precisely not a state; it consists in activity, because it is dynamic rather than static. It is activity in my life—and a last desperate version of the objection might claim that it's my life, not yours, so there is at bottom something egoistic about it. But my happiness is my living happily, and what life can I live other than mine? It would be absurd as well as objectionable for me to try to live your life. Eudaimonist accounts, then, will not have some people trying to live others' lives by imposing values and priorities on them. We have already seen a reason for this in the distinction between the living of my (and your) life and the circumstances of them. I can aid you to live your life by improving your circumstances, but it must always be up to you to live your life in those circumstances.

What of the second horn of the alleged dilemma? Strictly we need not consider it, since the first horn fails, but following up the issue of self-effacingness turns out to be illuminating about the present account of virtue. We can start by asking, What is *wrong* with self-effacingness? It seems an odd feature for a theory to have, but why should it discredit it?

[9] A possible exception is Epicurus.

We will get clarification here if we consider how self-effacingness arises for the theory in which it is most notorious, namely consequentialism. I am not here presenting an attack on consequentialism, merely pointing out a familiar feature of it, in the interests simply of making clear how and why self-effacingness is a problem for one kind of theory, so that I can then point out in contrast why it is not a problem for the kind of account of virtue I am sketching, either in itself or in the context of eudaimonism.

As has been recognized by consequentialists themselves for a century and a half, if our end should be to maximize some good consequence,[10] it will soon become patent that if everyone tries to employ a method so remote from our practical thinking, the result will not only not be good, it will actually be worse, from the theory's point of view, than the result would be if we did not employ the theory's method. So it looks as though the theory's aim is best achieved by its being aimed for not directly but indirectly, in a way that precludes its being achieved directly by everyone's using the theory's method.

This at once forces the issue, *by whom* is the theory's aim to be achieved? Answers have to divide into two the source from which the theory's inventors hope its achievement is to come. One scenario is that some people do have a clear view of the theory's aim,[11] and they achieve the theory's aim by manipulating others into achieving it. They do this by either withholding information or by misleading them into having motivations which have no reference to the theory's aim, but whose presence helps to bring it about. This unattractive scenario, which in its pure form has been mostly avoided, has aptly been called the 'Government House' version.[12]

Commoner is a scenario which at least takes into account the point that the theory is supposed to apply to everyone, and so assumes that, at least in principle, each individual can understand the consequentialists' aim, and also the point that our practical reasoning will not bring it about.[13] Hence

[10] It makes no difference here what the consequence is taken to be—pleasure, welfare, or whatever.

[11] Though *ex hypothesi* there will be a mystery how they, but not the rest of us, can acquire this clear view.

[12] The term comes from Bernard Williams. The colonials deem it impossible to enlighten the natives, so they manipulate them into achieving aims that the colonials deem enlightened.

[13] Given any normal methodology, this would amount to good reason for rejecting the theory. That defenders of the theory persist is an indication that, although it is taken as a

they are taken to understand that most of the time they should forget about the theory and follow reasons whose effect, but not their content, conforms to the theory. From time to time they are allowed to reflect on the theory itself directly, but most of the time they are achieving it indirectly, through following reasons whose content the theory rejects, but whose presence helps to achieve its aim. Thus the person's practical reasoning is quite explicitly split. Part of it is engaged in manipulating the other part into following reasons the following of which, though not the content, will further consequentialist aims. What of the unfortunate other part? Either it is too stupid to notice, or it somehow dumbs itself down into forgetting, or ceasing to mind, that it is being manipulated.

This split in the agent's practical reasoning is not in the least like a division to which it is often compared. This is what happens when we from time to time step back 'in a cool hour', detach ourselves from our ongoing reasonings and reflect about the ways we have been reasoning in our crowded and often hurried lives; we may criticize our ongoing reasoning from the point of view of a more detached and reflective vantage-point. These, however, are cases where reflection is prompted by felt difficulties at the everyday level of experience; it is the stress of everyday reasoning which triggers reflection that leads to solutions. This is nothing like the situation where the everyday level thinks that it is doing fine, and discerns no problem, but alleged problems, and their alleged solutions, are *imported* by the external reflection. In this case the external reflection does not solve or clarify the everyday reasoning's problems; it simply rejects everyday reasoning without arguing with it on its own terms.

The major problem created when a theory is self-effacing in this way is obvious enough: it renders impossible a unified account of practical reasoning. Since the theory promotes my acting on reasons whose content it rejects, I am all right as long as I act on those reasons in innocence of the theory (though innocence might be dangerous in the first scenario). But as soon as I discover the theory, there is no way I can unite the reasons it endorses and the reasons it directs me to act on. The problem with a theory's being self-effacing (at least an ethical theory with claims to guide the way we act) is that it can give no coherent account of the way we

source of directives as to what we should do, the theory is not thought of as one we can put into practice. We are owed an account of how we can still understand it as an *ethical* theory.

should reason when we act. And, for a theory aiming to guide practice, this is an outstanding flaw.[14]

To return to the alleged dilemma for eudaimonist virtue accounts: self-effacingness is a serious problem for a theory of the above form. However, while eudaimonist virtue accounts do require a *kind* of self-effacingness, it is entirely harmless. It comes in at two stages, in fact.

First, there is a way in which virtue comes to efface itself from the virtuous person's motivation; thoughts about virtue will no longer have an explicit place in the thoughts that lead the virtuous person to virtuous action. A beginner in virtue (usually a young person) will have to try to become virtuous, and to perform virtuous actions. His deliberations will explicitly include such thoughts as that *this* is what a virtuous (brave, etc.) person would do, or that *that* would be a virtuous (brave, etc.) action. By the time he has developed to being a truly virtuous person, he will not have to, and won't, think explicitly about being brave or doing a brave action. Rather he will, as a result of his experience, reflection, and habituation simply respond to the situation, 'from a disposition', because he thinks that people are in danger and need help. Thoughts about bravery or the brave person are no longer needed. We could say that they have effaced themselves. But they have not evaporated. They could be recovered if needed—if, for example, the person needs to explain what he did afterwards, say to a child who is being taught to be brave. In fact, if someone does brave actions but, when asked about them, can say absolutely nothing relevant, we might doubt whether he was really brave. If he can convey nothing as to why some dangers are worth running and others not, his actions don't determine whether he was brave or just foolhardy.[15]

It's obvious by now that this point is illuminated by the skill analogy. We merely need to recall the way in which the learning of virtue was introduced via illustrations of practical skill, and the way that virtue displays many of the same features. We do not find anything problematic in the fact that a skilled plumber, pianist, or marathon runner will respond to

[14] I am of course aware of the numerous moves that consequentialists make, in particular the move of insulating the truth of a supposedly applicable theory from the issue of its applicability. (Familiarity with these moves seems to have rendered many philosophers unworried by the bizarre nature of an ethical theory that precludes itself from being generally put into practice.) These moves fall outside the scope of this discussion.

[15] None of this presumes that others are always or indeed often in a position to determine this.

a challenge directly, without explicit thoughts about good plumbing, playing, or running. These are not needed, as they are in the apprentices, who need them in order to develop the expertise that will be exercised without reference to them. In everyday life nothing is more familiar or commonplace than this point about the development of a practical skill. On the present account of virtue we can see that and why it is not problematic for virtue either. We need, again, to remember that there is no all-purpose 'virtuous person'; there are learners and those who are like the experts, and virtue is always a matter of development, and will be different in the beginner and in the person in whom it has developed.

Second, however, what of the virtuous person's thoughts about happiness? Does she even need to have any? This may seem unlikely given the initial indeterminacy of happiness that has been so much insisted on. But here again we need to think in terms of development. When we learn to be brave and to be fair, there seems at first little or no reason to connect the two; the areas of life in which they are displayed, and the feelings and attitudes with which they deal, have little in common. Pluralist accounts of virtue maintain that we never get further than this in terms of connecting the virtues overall in a single life. We have seen, in Ch. 6, reasons for rejecting this view, reasons which rely on the centrality of practical reasoning in the development of the virtues. Here we need to focus on ways in which this development of overall practical reasoning applies to happiness.

We can bring this out even at the level of the individual virtues. Take someone who is learning to be brave, but who has no thoughts about happiness. He learns, that is, to stand up to bullying, to put forward an unpopular opinion, and to endure hardship and difficulty when this is needed to achieve an aim. In so far as he is learning to be *brave*, rather than merely stubborn, what he is learning must involve learning which aims are *worth* enduring hardship for, what the difference is between circumstances that do require you to stand up for an unpopular opinion and those in which it would be merely tactless or showing-off. And so on, as we have seen. He is learning about the value of acting bravely and being a brave person. How is this compatible with his having *no* views about his overall happiness? How could he have learnt these points about value, acting, responding, and feeling, and have had no thoughts at all about their implications for how he lives his life? If he really has no views on his life overall and which aims are worthwhile, to that extent he seems not to

have a virtue, but merely an inculcated routine habit, localized in his life without his drawing any implications from it, obvious though these may be.

Similarly if he does have views about happiness, but these are clearly misguided (in the present case, this need only mean that they would clearly be considered misguided by a reasonable range of ethical theories). Suppose he holds, for example, that what matters most in life is having a good time. If he really holds this, then again we can't think that the character he has developed is really that of a brave person; for bravery often requires that you forgo having a good time, and so the person who really holds this view, and so is committed to the having of good times, will just not notice many of the ways in which bravery should be called forth. Again, we look to have local routinized habit, not a virtue. For this person to develop in such a way as genuinely to become brave, the first thing he would have to do would be to think again about what *matters* in his life and what his view is of his happiness.

We can see from this that the virtuous person does have thoughts about happiness, and that they become more determinate as the person becomes more virtuous. To become brave requires you to accept that some things, and not others, are valuable in your life and, to that extent, your life has acquired a shape it did not have before your character developed in this way. This has been presented as a point about the development of virtue, but if we accept the point that we are always developing—as we live our lives, our work is never done—it is clear that there is always a dynamic relationship between the development of virtues and the person's conception of their happiness. Sometimes this can be very dramatic, as with people whose values undergo a radical conversion. As somebody arrogant becomes modest, say, the development of modesty, with the required revisions in her opinions of the respect due to other people, will go along with the development of a different conception of the kind of life she aims at living, the kind of person she now aims to be. Discovering respect for other people and their views goes hand in hand with developing a view of your life in which you now rebuke yourself for not taking account of the views of others, actively aspire to do, and be, what you despised before, and so on.

This is even more marked if we think not just of single virtues but of the development of virtue as a whole. As your character as a whole develops, in so far as it develops towards a more integrated overall structure, your

view of happiness will likewise become more integrated; commitment to conflicting values will weaken to the extent that your character develops connections among the virtues related to those values. The ideal development produces a unified view of what is worthwhile and worth pursuing in your life, a determinate conception of your happiness which both encourages and is encouraged by a unified development of your character. This is, of course, an ideal, one that we are always some distance from. (And, to repeat, this is unification of happiness in relation to *virtue*, to the *living* of your life; it does not imply that you either should, or should not, always try to remove conflict in the circumstances of your life.)

The virtuous person will, then, have thoughts about happiness as she develops in virtue, and these will make her conception of happiness increasingly determinate as her character develops. Does this give us something which opens the present account to the charge that virtue must be self-effacing in a problematic way? Clearly not; for the same account will obviously be given as we saw above for virtue. As you become more virtuous (brave, or whatever) your thoughts about happiness become more determinate, but they also need to play less of an explicit role in your deliberations, for just the same reasons as thoughts about doing the brave thing, or being a brave person, do. And this is because, as we have just seen, your conception of happiness develops along with, and corresponding to, your thoughts about first individual virtues and, increasingly, character as a whole. So explicit thoughts about happiness gradually become effaced from explicit deliberations, along with explicit thoughts about virtue, but can be recalled and reactivated if required, for explanation and teaching. Nothing in this gives any opening for a split in the self, or a problem for unified deliberation.

So we find that we have the resources to break the alleged dilemma. When we reflect about the relation of virtue and happiness, we find that both are central to the way we think about our lives. As we develop the virtues, we may begin to do so for reasons that come from happiness; but even where this is the case it does not give rise either to defensible charges of egoism, or to charges that the theory requires a damaging way in which thoughts about virtue and happiness come to efface themselves in the person's deliberations.

We should bear in mind at this point that eudaimonist accounts come in many different kinds. They differ over the relation of virtue to happiness (partly constitutive, necessary, sufficient) and they also differ, as we have

seen, in the account they give of the way the virtues express a commitment to goodness and to the kind of goodness that is committed to. The above remarks therefore stay at a very high level of generality, given the different accounts of virtue and of the relation of virtue to happiness. It is possible for a eudaimonist account of virtue to be egoistic, as Epicurus' account arguably is; but we can see from the above that this implies that there is going to be something controversial in the account of virtue.

The Skill Analogy Revisited

Exploration of the way that virtue and happiness fit together in a eudaimonist account of virtue has shown us the strengths and resources of the skill analogy. We have just seen that it is the fact that virtue is 'self-effacing' in the way that practical skills are (that is, that explicit reasons in terms of virtue cease to be explicitly present in the person's deliberations) that enables us to see how virtue in a eudaimonist account is not egoistic in any way. It also enables us to see how natural it is for us to come to think of living virtuously as (at least partly) constituting living happily. Our conception of happiness becomes more determinate as we become more virtuous; as our character develops, we come to have a more integrated view of what is worth having and doing in life, and again this happens in a way which ceases to be explicit in our deliberations, but is still present in a way that can be recalled if required.

Another strength of the skill analogy is the way that it makes us foreground teaching and learning when we are thinking of a virtue. It encourages us to realize that we do not have an adequate account of a virtue until we have an account of how it is taught and learned; and this in turn encourages us not to develop an account which focuses exclusively on mature adults. Theories which do this tend to ignore the idea that the development of a virtue might actually be an essential part of the account of a virtue. We have seen how, if we take the developmental aspect seriously, we can give their proper roles to a number of points about virtue. One is the point about aspiration; virtue is always an ideal that we aspire to, and so we are always developing towards or away from it. Connected is the point that virtue is essentially dynamic, not a static condition of the person but an aspect of him or her that is always developing for the better or the worse. Our work, in living virtuously, is

never done. (We may find this point inspiring, or depressing, depending on temperament.) Moreover, in a eudaimonist account we are now able to give substance to the idea that happiness is something to be achieved in activity rather than a passive experience.

Moreover, the skill analogy, with its emphasis on development, enables us to avoid problems that arise if we think solely of 'the virtuous person', forgetting that we are always dealing with people at various stages of development. This helps us to see why we should not expect the account to deliver a single one-size-fits-all decision procedure, of any kind, which would tell everyone what to do, whatever their circumstances and stage of virtuous development. And this in turn connects with realizing that this kind of theory will not deliver a 'theory of right action' or an account of 'the right thing to do' independent of the virtuous thing to do, or a decision-procedure telling everyone what to do. It is the aspects of virtue illuminated by the skill analogy which enable us to allow fully for the embeddedness of the way that virtues are acquired and exercised, while not falling into danger of relativism; for we do not lose sight of virtue as an ideal that we aspire to in a way that crosses communities and cultures. In all these ways we find that we have an account of virtue which makes it natural and fruitful to think of living virtuously as being (at least partly) constitutive of living happily.

All these points give us an attractive picture of the happy life. On this account it is not a fun state that we struggle to achieve and then relax, as though we were working at an uncongenial job in order to retire and forget about the work we did to get there. Rather happiness, living happily, is always an ongoing activity. It is an ongoing project, and so very different to accounts in terms of feeling good or getting what you want or being satisfied. This is an account of happiness which emphasizes activity and engagement rather than passive experiences.

Virtue, Goodness, and Living Happily

So far in this chapter there has been less emphasis than the reader might expect on the points about virtue explored in Ch. 7, points which do not stem from the skill analogy. This is because the present account is comprehensive about ways in which virtue involves commitment to goodness, and hence discussion of this point has to stay at a high level of generality.

As discussed in Ch. 7, living virtuously can involve commitment to a conception of the good which transcends human life, often religious or spiritual. It can also involve commitment to a conception of good to be achieved in living a human life, and this naturalistic kind of theory can in turn take a circumstantial or non-circumstantial form. The present eudaimonist account of virtue thus covers a range of different accounts of the virtuous life currently on offer, both secular and religious, and of their relation to living happily. I take it that this level of comprehensiveness is an advantage in an account like the present one, which aims to work out the general lines of a eudaimonist account of virtue, rather than to present and to argue for one specific version. Each variant will need its own arguments and evidence, but their conflicts occur within a framework that they share. In this they all differ radically from theories of a consequentialist and Kantian kind, and cannot be considered mere variants of one or other of these. We have a distinct family of theories that needs to be understood in its own terms rather than being bent out of shape in analyses which fit only consequentialist and Kantian theories.

But Is It Happiness?

But is it *happiness*? Is it enjoyable? By now we do not need to point out yet again that we are concerned with happiness as *eudaimonia*, not with pleasant feelings and desire-satisfaction. But once we have thoroughly cleared these passive conceptions out of the way, what do we still need? What is lacking? Happiness is (at least in part) constituted by virtuous activity, and it is itself, as has been stressed, activity; and we have seen how this is itself enjoyable. A final way in which the skill analogy helps us to understand both virtue and happiness lies in the way in which we find that enjoyment lies in active engagement with what we are doing and how we are living, rather than in waiting around for pleasant feelings.

The virtuous person is happy living their life, in so far as that is virtuous; and this is not a far-fetched and ridiculously high-minded idea we have no reason to accept, but a view of life which develops readily from the way we think about virtue and happiness, if we start from the perspective we have which illuminates them. Our perspective is one in which we start by thinking about how we act in the world in ways that we can do better and worse—the perspective of practical expertise. It is not blank 'know-how'

but skill in which we can become experts. This idea of developing skill is, as we have seen, surprisingly complex to untangle, and we have seen how it corresponds closely to virtue, since after all virtue is, among other things, an example of how we act in the world in ways that we can do better and worse.[16]

Throughout these two chapters I have insisted that living happily is '(at least in part)' living virtuously, and this constant qualification may have seemed coy. I have insisted on it because I think that this is the position that emerges from our conceptions of virtue and happiness when we explore them. We want to be good people, and we want our children to be good people also, because this will be better for us, and for them. But we also want to be successful, attractive, popular, wealthy, and many other things. Most of us do not succeed in working out an overall consistent view among these many things we want until we start reflecting seriously. So for most of us the happy life is enjoyable because it consists in part in virtuous activity, and this is enjoyable. But it also contains enjoyment from other sources. Someone living this kind of life is likely to feel satisfaction when they look back and reflect on the way they have lived. But most of us also take some of the circumstances of our lives to be parts of our living happily. We enjoy having money, security, and status, and feel that we would not continue to live happily without these. Hence we think that items such as money and status are also needed for happiness, as well as living well. These things do matter to most of us also in themselves and not only as circumstances enabling us to live virtuous lives. (It remains a mistake, of course, to think that these kinds of thing on their own could make us happy—a less common mistake.)[17]

So we find that the ordinary view of virtue and happiness is a mixed one. Many of us implicitly take happiness to require both being a good person *and also* (in their own right) some amount of money, security, status, and so on. This is the point at which philosophical debate starts. Can you be made happy by aiming to be a good person, *and also* by money, security, and status? Or is this an essentially unstable position? We have

[16] The reader may have by now made up his or her mind as to whether we have a 'skill *analogy*' or the conclusion that virtue is itself a kind of skill.

[17] 'Happiness studies' that give us *Consumer Reports* types of suggestions (see n. 5) on 'how to be happy' by being healthy, having good marriages, and so on, notice that these things are important constituents of many people's idea of happiness, but fail to notice that more is involved, namely the way we deal with these things.

seen that it is part of our everyday views about happiness that stuff alone doesn't make you happy. Could it be part of what living happily requires? If so, how important a part? Could money, status, and the like make you happy only if you are a good person, and not if you are evil? What about the mediocre—are they made happy by these things?

If virtue is necessary for happiness, then someone who fails to live virtuously is not happy, however much stuff she has and however many feelings of pleasure and satisfaction she has. This is a position we need to be persuaded of by philosophical argument; it does not just emerge from reflecting about virtue and happiness. We should note, though, that we need argument to reject it also; everyday reflection does not just rule it out, though philosophers surprisingly often think that it does and that argument is not necessary here. We can always, of course point to evil people having what they take to be enjoyable lives; but clearly by now this misses the mark if thought of as a counterexample to the present claim. Given the complexity of our conceptions of virtue and of happiness, this is not surprising. Bernard Williams makes a claim which has been frequently repeated, that we can see horrible people who do not seem to be unhappy at all, but by the 'standard of the bright eye and gleaming coat' are doing very well. Those who quote this, however, generally fail to continue the thought, which is that it is unclear whether there are such people. We imagine them, but this may just be a projection of our own thoughts. Williams suggests that a sign that this is indeed the case is that we can imagine examples that are attractive, rather than repellent, only by focusing on the partly imagined past, rather than contemporary examples.[18] It is extremely difficult to produce examples both of real, current wickedness which are also convincing examples of happiness.

We need yet further philosophical argument to convince us that living virtuously is actually sufficient for living happily, so that living happily resides entirely in the living of your life, with its circumstances having a different kind of value which, while important to your life, does not itself contribute to living happily. To get to this position we have to become convinced that there is a latent incoherence in thinking of happiness as

[18] Williams (1985: 46). The bright eye and gleaming coat are in any case signs of animal flourishing rather than the kind of flourishing appropriate to humans, who live in a world of mortgages, marriages, and other mundane but essentially *human* conventions.

made up both of living virtuously and of items such as money and status, which belong with life's circumstances rather than with the living of it.[19]

These are philosophical positions with thousands of years of tradition of debate behind them, and contemporary debate is beginning to catch up with the ways that they arise in eudaimonist accounts.[20] Happiness is again becoming the site where ordinary reflection and philosophical argument intersect. The traffic is two-way: lived situations give rise to problems that require philosophical treatment, and philosophical conclusions require us to rethink the ways we live our lives.

[19] I myself tend to the sufficiency position, on the basis of arguments (such as the above), not just on the basis of our conceptions of virtue and happiness (although the position is not in fact as hopelessly unintuitive as it is sometimes claimed to be).

[20] Russell (forthcoming) discusses the appeal of the sufficiency thesis and its connection to different conceptions of agency.